'Right! Remember the tiny penknife he gave me last year, the one with a genuine shark's tooth blade. That's been really useful,' Maya joined the protest.

'No one but you, Maya,' Mrs.Krishnan told her daughter sternly,'would describe a penknife that has cut open the pockets of three skirts and two pairs of jeans as *really useful*.'

'And what about the aboriginal boomerang Uncle Somu brought us all the way from Australia?' demanded Arvind. 'You can't deny that it was a great hit with everyone.'

'Great hit indeed!' Mrs.Krishnan didn't bother to hide her sarcasm and continued, 'Considering that the boomerang sliced through all the TV aerials in the neighbourhood, caused permanent damage to several cars in the parking lot, and knocked out our watchman cold, with the force you threw it.'

'But Zigzag is different. Somu says we are sure to love Zigzag,' soothed Dr.Krishnan, 'because the bird can talk and sing in about twenty-one different language __ mostly African languages, of course. When it sings, it moves the listeners to tears.'

'It's Somu's thoughtless ways that reduce me to tears!' Mrs.Krishnan said irritably. 'What a time to dump this multilingual, talking-singing bird on us. Here I'm tied up in knots trying to get my paintings together for the exhibition next week.'

'May I take Zigzag to school, Papa?' Arvind, as always, was planning ahead. 'I want to display him in the science exhibition.'

'When is Zigzag coming, Papa?' Maya was jumping up and down, all excited.

'Uncle Somu said he would send Zigzag with his old cook, Visu, sometime today. I'll have to leave for my clinic now. There,' he added as the doorbell rang, 'that's probably them!'

And indeed it was!

'Come in, Zigzag, come in, dear! 'coazedVisu, and in tottered the strangest, weirdest-looking bird the Krishnan family had ever seen.

About a foot and a half tall, its bald head was fringed with a crown of shocking pink feathers while the rest of its plumage was in various shades of the muddiest sludgiest brown. Its curved beak was sunflower-yellow and its eyes were the colour of cola held to sunlight.

'This is Zigzag! Announced Visu with a flourish. 'His full name is Ziggy-Zagga-king-of-the-Tonga. How I'm going to miss him! So beautifully he talks! He can even recite French Poetry!'

The object of all this praise was standing cool and unmoved, with an expression of almost-human grumpiness in his cola-coloured eyes.

Arvind, finding that Zigzag was sulkily refusing to say a word despite all

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